

COUNCIL – 27 MAY 2026

Report title: Review of Allocation of Seats to Political Groups

Wards: All

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REPORT SUMMARY

A review of the allocation of seats to political groups is legally required at, or as soon as practicable after, each Annual Meeting of the Council or when notice is received of a change in the composition of a political group. Having undertaken this review, the Council then has a duty to make appointments (where necessary), to those committees. The seats are allocated to particular members based on the wishes expressed by the political groups.

FINANCE SUMMARY

There are no financial implications arising from this report.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Full Council is asked to:

1. Note the overall Party split of seats and seat entitlements on the Council as set out in 2.4 of the report.
2. Approve (where the rules of political balance apply), the recommended allocation of seats and size of committees to the Ordinary Committees and, as set out in 2.9 of the report.
3. Approve (where the rules of political balance do not apply), the recommended allocation of seats and size of committees to the Statutory Committees and Board as set out in 2.13 of the report.
4. Approve (where the rules of political balance do not apply), the recommended allocation of seats and size of committees to the Non-Ordinary and Sub Committees as set out in 2.17 of the report.

1. CONTEXT

- 1.1 Following the Local Elections on Thursday 7 May 2026 and subsequent resignations, the composition of the Council is Green Party (27 seats) Labour (26 seats), and Liberal Democrats (8 seats) with 2 casual vacancies.
- 1.2 Section 15(1) of the Local Government and Housing Act 1989 (the Act) requires the Council to review the representation of the different political groups on committees and for committees to do the same for their sub-committees:
 - At or as soon as practicable after, the Annual Meeting of the Council or
 - As soon as practicable after notice is received of a change in the composition of political groups.
- 1.3 The Chief Executive submits this report to the Council showing what allocation of seats would in his opinion best meet the requirements of Section 15 of the Act.

2. PROPOSAL AND REASONS

- 1.1 Section 15 of the Act requires the Council to apply the political proportionality rules '*so far as reasonably practicable*' when determining the allocation of seats on committees and other bodies to which the rules apply.
- 1.2 It is therefore appropriate to apply the "least deviation principle" which enables the Council to arrive at an allocation which gives effect, '*so far as is reasonably practicable*' (as required by section 15 of the Act), to the principles.
- 2.1 The principles apply sequentially, as it may not be possible to satisfy them all fully. Principle B cannot override principle A; principle C cannot override principles A and B; and principle D cannot override principles A, B and C. We set out below some further comments in relation to each of the principles.

Principle A – this is a relatively self-explanatory principle and the most important sequentially, stating that not all the seats on a body can be allocated to members of the same political group. It is to be noted that this does not require that each political group needs to be represented on each body.

Principle B – where a majority of the members of Council are members of the same political group, a majority of the seats on the body must be allocated to that political group. So where there is a majority group, they must be allocated a minimum of 2 seats on a 3 member committee or sub-committee, 3 seats on a committee or sub-committee of 4 members, and so on. This can mean that where a political group enjoys a narrow majority, that group will be allocated significantly more seats than would result from simple proportionality. This principle together with principle A reinforces the point that the minimum committee or sub-committee size should be 3.

Principle C – deals with the aggregate of seats on all 'ordinary committees' taken together. It does not apply to ordinary sub-committees, statutory committees, joint committees or outside bodies. It requires that, subject to principles A and B, the number of seats allocated to a political group on each ordinary committee bears the same proportion to the total of all of the seats on the ordinary committees of the Council as the proportion of that group's members to the overall membership of the Council. This is of course subject to being so far as is reasonably practicable as per section 15(4) of the LGHA.

Principle D – this requires the number of seats allocated to a political group on a body to be in the same proportion as the number of members of that group to the number of members of the Council as a whole, subject to principles A to C.

2.4 Overall split on the Council

The seats on the Council are split as set out below in the Table. The rounded total produces 33 seats, leaving 2 vacant seats. Seats are to be allocated using the principle of least deviation.

Party	Seats	Calculation	Exact seat entitlement	Rounded up/down Seat entitlement
Green	27	27/63	15	15
Labour	26	26/63	14.44	14
Liberal Democrats	8	8/63	4.44	4
Vacancy	2	2/63	0	0
Total	63		35	33

2.5 Ordinary Committees

The Council has seven ordinary committees to which the duty to achieve political proportionality applies. Table 2 below shows the proposed number of seats on each committee which total 35.

Committee	Number of seats
Appointments	5
Audit and Risk	5
General Purposes	5
Planning	7
Standards	5
Pensions Committee	5
Investigating Committee	3
Total	35

2.6 In the Council's case principles A and B would not be relevant to the calculations on the basis that the Council has no overall majority political group. This means that with reference to the Ordinary Committees, the Council would follow principle C and then D.

Principle C calculation – overall share

Green – $27/63 \times 35 = 15$ rounding to 15

Labour – $26/63 \times 35 = 14.44$ rounding to 14

Lib Dem – $8/63 \times 35 = 4.44$ rounding to 4

This gives a total seat allocation of 33 seats which leaves 2 seats to be allocated.

Council then needs to look at the decimals and apply the “principle of least deviation”. The seats should be allocated to the group with the highest decimals without gaining a seat.

Here both Labour and Lib Dems have the same highest decimal without gaining a seat at 0.44 – they will both gain a seat in this instance which deals with the 2 unallocated seats.

The allocation of the 35 seats on the Ordinary Committees under principle C is as follows:

Green – 15

Labour – 15

Lib Dem – 5

2.7 Principle D calculation – individual committees

Having worked out how many committee seats are to be allocated to each political group, Principle D then determines which committees those seats relate to.

So Principle D now says that, taking each committee separately, we have to ensure that the seats on that committee are allocated as close to proportionately as possible, without offending Principles A, B or C. Here Principles A and B are not relevant, so the focus is on ensuring that seats are allocated on Ordinary Committees under Principle D without offending Principle C.

Appointments – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

Audit and Risk – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

General Purposes – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

Planning Applications – 7 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 7 = 3$	3
Labour	$26/63 \times 7 = 2.88$	3
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 7 = 0.88$	1

Standards – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

Investigating – 3 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 3 = 1.28$	1
Labour	$26/63 \times 3 = 1.23$	1
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 3 = 0.38$	0

This leaves one seat to be filled.

Pensions Committee – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

2.8 This gives the following total seats on the Ordinary Committees:

Green – 14 (1 short of allocation under Principle C)

Labour – 14 (1 short of allocation under Principle C)

Lib Dem – 6 (1 more than allocation under principle C)

There is a need to make adjustments so as to comply with principle C – this takes precedence to allocating an unallocated seat to an ungrouped member – if there remain unallocated seats after the adjustments required to comply with principle C, then these will go to the ungrouped member.

Therefore, the Greens and Labour need to gain 1 seat each, and the Lib Dems need to lose one seat.

The spare seat on the Investigating Committee would go to the Greens because they have the highest decimal without gaining a seat (Lib Dems are discounted here because they already need to lose a seat). This still leaves Labour 1 short, and the Lib Dems still need to lose a seat.

2.9 Seat allocations – with adjustments

COMMITTEE	TOTAL Ctte Seats	GREEN	LABOUR	LIBERAL DEMOCRATS
1. Appointments	5	2	2	1
2. Audit and Risk	5	2	2	1
3. General Purposes	5	2	3	0
4. Planning Applications	7	3	3	1
5. Standards Ctte	5	2	3	0
6. Investigating Ctte	3	2	1	0
7. Pensions Ctte	5	2	2	1
TOTALS	35	15	15	5

2.10 Statutory Committees/Boards

These are committees/boards to which the political proportionality rules do not apply, but are often applied voluntarily by local authorities.

Committee	Total
Health and Wellbeing Board	5
Licensing	10
Pensions Board	3

Should the Council wish to apply the political proportionality rules to these committees/boards, then it would only be principle D that would be relevant.

2.11 Principle D calculation – individual committees

Principle D determines (without reference to principle C, or A or B as they are not relevant) which group gets which committee/board seats.

Health and Wellbeing Board – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

Licensing – 10 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 10 = 4.28$	5
Labour	$26/63 \times 10 = 4.12$	4
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 10 = 1.26$	1

Pensions Board – 3 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 3 = 1.28$	1
Labour	$26/63 \times 3 = 1.23$	1
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 3 = 0.38$	0

Leaving one seat to be filled on the Pensions Board.

- 2.12 On the basis of the vacant seats on the Council being classed as ungrouped, and that the Council is voluntarily applying the political proportionality rules to these committees/boards, then the unallocated seat is allocated to the ungrouped members (being the vacant seats on the Council).

In reality of course there are no ungrouped members to take up that seat, and therefore it should be determined by full Council which member of the Council shall sit in this unallocated seat. This is not a case of allocating the seat to a group – the seat will remain allocated to ungrouped members, but full Council determines which member of the Council sits in it.

2.13 Seat allocation with adjustments

Committee	Total Ctte seats	Green	Labour	Liberal Democrats
Health and Wellbeing Board	5	2	2	1
Licensing	10	5	4	1
Pensions Board	3	1	1	1

2.14 Non-ordinary and Sub-Committees

In the Council's case principles A and B would not be relevant to the calculations on the basis that the Council has no overall majority political group.

Also, we are not required to apply principle C because it only applies to Ordinary Committees only.

This means that with reference to the other committees, the Council would follow principle D only.

2.15 Principle D calculation – individual committees

Principle D determines (without reference to principle C, or A or B as they are not relevant) which group gets which committee seats.

Overview and Scrutiny – 9 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 9 = 3.85$	4
Labour	$26/63 \times 9 = 3.71$	4
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 9 = 1.14$	1

Appointments Sub Committee – 5 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 5 = 2.14$	2

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Labour	$26/63 \times 5 = 2.06$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 5 = 0.63$	1

Standards Hearing Sub-Committee – 3 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 3 = 1.28$	1
Labour	$26/63 \times 3 = 1.23$	1
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 3 = 0.38$	0

Leaving one seat to be filled

Adults Social Care and Health Scrutiny Sub-Committee – 6 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 6 = 2.57$	3
Labour	$26/63 \times 6 = 2.47$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 6 = 0.76$	1

Children's Services Scrutiny Sub-Committee – 6 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 6 = 2.57$	3
Labour	$26/63 \times 6 = 2.47$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 6 = 0.76$	1

Housing Scrutiny Sub-Committee – 6 seats

Party	Entitlement ((no. in group/total Cllrs) x seats on committee)	Rounded
Green	$27/63 \times 6 = 2.57$	3
Labour	$26/63 \times 6 = 2.47$	2
Lib Dem	$8/63 \times 6 = 0.76$	1

2.16 There is a spare seat on the Standards Hearing Sub-Committee which needs to be allocated.

There is no requirement to comply with principle C in relation to these committees, and therefore the unallocated seat is allocated to the ungrouped members (being the vacant seats on the Council).

2.17 Seat allocations with adjustments

COMMITTEE	TOTAL Ctte Seats	GREEN	LABOUR	LIBERAL DEMOCRATS
1. Overview and Scrutiny	9	4	4	1
2. Appointment Sub Committee	5	2	2	1
3. Standards Hearing Sub Committee	3	1	1	1
4. Adult Social Care Sub Committee	6	3	2	1
5. Children's Scrutiny Sub Committee	6	3	2	1
6. Housing Scrutiny Sub Committee	6	3	2	1

2.18 Following the allocation by the Council, or a committee, of a seat or seats on a committee or sub-committee respectively, Section 15 of the Act provides that the appointments to the seats should be carried out as soon as practicable. To that end, Regulation 15 of The Local Government (Committees and Political Groups) Regulations 1990 provides for a backstop period of three weeks from the date that notice of allocation of seats on committees is given to groups to express their wishes in relation to the appointment to such a seat or seats. If there is a failure to express wishes within the prescribed period, the Council (and in the case of a seat on a sub-committee, the committee), may make such appointment to that seat or seats as they see fit. Further, the group to which a seat has been allocated is entitled to express a wish that the seat be filled by a member of a different political party or an ungrouped member, though in such a case the member would be entitled to refuse to take up the seat. However, in any event, that seat remains, in law, allocated to the first group and that group therefore retains the right to terminate the appointment.

3. FINANCE

3.1 There are no capital or revenue financial implications arising as a direct result of this report.

4. LEGAL AND DEMOCRACY

- 4.1 The legal implications are covered in Section 2 above, and generally. In particular, confirmation is given of the legal requirement to recognise the Independent Member in determining how seats are to be allocated to the committees which require political balance as set out at Tables 2 and 3 above. In order to facilitate both Opposition Groups being represented on Overview and Scrutiny Committee, the Labour Group has agreed to give up one of its entitlements. That move is permissible pursuant to section 17(1) of the Local Government and Housing Act 1989 but would need to be agreed upon without any member of the Council voting against the change.
- 4.2 No additional comments from Democratic Services.

5. CONSULTATION AND CO-PRODUCTION

- 5.1 None.

6. RISK MANAGEMENT

- 6.1 None.

7. EQUALITIES IMPACT ASSESSMENT

- 7.1 None.

8. COMMUNITY SAFETY

- 8.1 None.

9. CHILD FRIENDLY LAMBETH

- 9.1 None.

10. ORGANISATIONAL IMPLICATIONS

Environmental

- 10.1 None.

Health

- 10.2 None.

Staffing and accommodation

- 10.3 None.

Responsible Procurement

- 10.4 None.

11. TIMETABLE FOR IMPLEMENTATION

- 11.1 Not applicable.

AUDIT TRAIL

Name and Position/Title	Lambeth Directorate	Date Sent	Date Received	Comments in paragraph:
Raymond Prince, Director of Legal and Governance	Resources	26.05.2026		Throughout
Chloe Morris, Senior Democratic Services Officer	Resources	26.05.2026		

REPORT HISTORY

Report deadline	
Date final report sent	
Part II Exempt from Disclosure/confidential accompanying report?	No
Key decision report	No
Date first appeared on forward plan	N/A
Key decision reasons	N/A
Background information	Relevant Legislation: Local Government and Housing Act 1989 Local Government (Committees and Political Groups) Regulations 1990
Appendices	None